HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

Interrelated Character Traits and Purity of Actions: HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem, Chapters 2-3

Given Monday 23 February 2026 · HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem

Sefer: *Ha-Maspik L'Ovdei Hashem* by Rabbeinu Avraham ben HaRambam
Scope: Completion of Perek Aleph, Perek Bet (full), and beginning of Perek Gimel

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Background & Recap

- The sefer has **13 chapters**, some much longer than others. The first three are relatively short and serve as introductory material.
- Previous shiurim covered a biography of Rabbi Avraham ben HaRambam and began Chapter 1.

Chapter 1 (Perek Aleph) — Completion

Recap: Two Paths of Serving Hashem

Rabbi Avraham establishes two fundamental paths of divine service:

1. **Derech Ha'Am HaGluyah (The Revealed Path):** The basic, universal path — observance of mitzvot. This is straightforward and doesn't have as many gradations. Either you observe or you don't (though there is some range in *how* you perform mitzvot).
2. **The Intimate / Lofty Path (Derech HaSegula):** Going beyond the letter of the law. This is the subject of the entire sefer. Within this path, there are **many levels and gradations**. The analogy given previously: three people all keeping Shabbat with extra intention, yet the gap between their levels is vast.

Key Point: You Cannot Skip Steps

Core Principle: Before pursuing the intimate, lofty path, one must first master the basics.

The Vilna Gaon's Interpretation of the Pasuk:

- *"V'lo ta'aleh b'ma'alot al mizbechi"* (Shemot 20:23) — the altar had to be a ramp, not steps.
- The Vilna Gaon explains: Don't "jump up steps" — don't skip rungs on the ladder of spiritual growth. It must be like a ramp: gradual, steady ascent.

Personal Anecdote — The Siddur HaRashash:

The teacher recalled encountering someone who prayed from the *Siddur HaRashash*, a kabbalistic siddur where each word of the Amidah fills an entire page of meditations (each

Amidah taking about an hour). He was deeply impressed — until he saw that same person flagrantly violating basic mitzvot. This illustrated the core problem: engaging in lofty spiritual practices while neglecting fundamentals is hollow.

The Text Inside

Hebrew: *"V'lifnei shenatchil bazot... ki hashkafah nechonah v'haseder hana'ot mechayevim linkoт techilah b'derech hagluyah."*

Translation/Explanation: Before discussing the intimate path, we must state: a proper outlook requires one to first take the basic, revealed path.

Key Passage: *"Ki da'ut gasah hi"* — It is a brazen, terrible mistake — *"sheyeha ploni muchzak chasid b'einav u'v'einei zulato"* — for a person to consider himself a Chasid (or be considered one by others) just because he:

- Doesn't marry (delays marriage)
- Fasts excessively
- Abstains from food
- Wears uncomfortable woolen garments

...while simultaneously **transgressing positive and negative commandments**.

Terminology Reminder

In Rabbi Avraham's lexicon:

- **Tzadik** = one who keeps the mitzvot properly
- **Chasid** = one who goes *beyond* the exact requirements of the mitzvot

"V'lo Am Ha'aretz Chasid"

Rabbi Avraham quotes Chazal: **An ignorant person (Am Ha'aretz) cannot be a Chasid.**

- An Am Ha'aretz will inevitably violate mitzvot due to ignorance.
- If one claims ignorance as an excuse, this itself proves a violation of *Talmud Torah* (the obligation to study), which is the most important mitzvah.

Why Learn This If We Haven't Perfected the Basics?

The teacher raised the honest question: shouldn't we focus on fixing our basic observance before studying these lofty topics?

Answer: At minimum, we gain **aspirations**. If you aspire high, you reach reasonably high. If you aspire to mediocrity, you fall below even that. Learning about the lofty path sets the bar we aim for.

Clarification on "Not Marrying"

- Rabbi Avraham does **not** promote celibacy. He himself married and had two sons (David and Ovadia).
- His son clarified in a footnote: the custom was for some to **delay** marriage to focus on Torah study, a concept found in the Gemara.

- Another interpretation: they would marry but spend time away studying, returning home only for Shabbat (sleeping in the Beit Midrash during the week).
- **Connection to Hilchot Shabbat:** The concept of a "temporary knot" (up to 7 days) is derived from this practice — Talmidei Chachamim would only untie their shoes upon returning home Friday afternoon.
- **Critical caveat:** Any such arrangement must be done with the spouse's **consent and happiness**. Neglecting spousal obligations while pursuing "chassidut" defeats the purpose.

Rabbeinu Bahya's Mashal (from Chovot HaLevavot)

Rabbi Avraham quotes Rabbeinu Bahya ibn Pakuda:

- **Extra prayers** are like a **gift** (matanah).
- **Obligatory prayers** are like **paying a debt** (pir'on chov).
- A creditor will **not accept a gift** from someone who hasn't paid their debt.

Practical application: Men are obligated to pray three times a day; women one or two. The Gemara says you *can* pray additional Amidot on weekdays (adding something new each time). But there's no point in extra prayers if you don't pray Shacharit, Mincha, and Arvit at their proper times.

Analogy: If you owe someone £100 and bring them a silver dish worth £150, they'll say: "That's lovely — but give me my £100 first."

A New Interpretation: "V'lo Yikach Shochad" (Devarim 10:17)

The problem: What does it mean that "Hashem doesn't take a bribe"? How would one bribe God?

Existing approaches:

- **Rashi:** You can't appease God with money.
- **Ramban & Sforno:** *Shochad mitzvot* — you can't "bribe" God by doing many mitzvot to cancel out sins. Each mitzvah is rewarded; each sin must be dealt with separately. No "netting."

Rabbi Avraham's novel interpretation: *V'lo yikach shochad* means Hashem doesn't accept "gifts" (extra spiritual practices) when you haven't fulfilled the basic obligations.

The Prophet Yeshayahu's Rebuke

Rabbi Avraham cites Yeshayahu (Chapter 58):

"Call out loudly... declare to My people their transgressions... They seek Me daily, they desire to know My ways, like a nation that performed righteousness... they ask Me for righteous judgments, they desire closeness to God."

The people *want* to be close to God and *seek* Him — but they haven't addressed their basic sins. What's the point of seeking closeness while violating fundamentals?

The Psychology of Shortcuts

Why do people skip the basics?

- Keeping all the mitzvot daily is **hard, unglamorous work**.

- Extra fasting, learning Kabbalah, extra prayers give a **spiritual "high"** — they feel good and dramatic.
- It's the "easy path" — a shortcut to feeling spiritual without doing the hard daily grind.

But there are no shortcuts in Torah. The Meshech Chochmah makes a similar point regarding Har Sinai.

Student's comment (Simon Cohen): This is exactly the pattern — someone replaces the difficult daily commitment (e.g., praying three times a day) with a dramatic one-off (e.g., a big fast). Rabbi Avraham says: no, the basics come first, even though they're less exciting.

Key distinction: There's a difference between things that make you *feel* good individually vs. your actual *obligations*.

Extreme Examples

Rabbi Avraham drives the point home with stark examples:

1. **Ten years of fasting** can be spiritually nullified by **one act of eating stolen food**.
2. **Years of wearing uncomfortable clothes** (as abstinence) can be lost by **wearing a four-cornered garment without tzitzit**.
3. **Years of living as a hermit in the mountains** can be lost by **living in a house without a mezuzah**.

Important caveat: This doesn't mean the mitzvot literally "cancel out" — what you've done is done. But the **spiritual growth and closeness to Hashem** that the extra practices were building can be undone by neglecting basics.

If it happened by mistake (*b'shogeg* or *b'ones*), one can ask for forgiveness.

Story of Abba Chilkiya

- **Abba Chilkiya** was the grandson of Choni HaMa'agel (who famously drew a circle and demanded rain).
- He and his wife had reached such a level that their joint prayers for rain were answered.
- When he returned from a journey, his wife came out **adorned and attractive**.
- The Chachamim asked why. He explained: **so that he wouldn't even be tempted to look at another woman**.
- Not that anyone suspected him — but out of **fear of the Yetzer Hara**. Even the greatest can stumble, and one stumble could destroy years of spiritual growth.

Lesson: The Chachamim went to extraordinary lengths to protect against basic sins, because all their "extra" spiritual achievements depended on maintaining the foundation.

The Rambam Connection (Doron's Insight)

A student (Doron) connected this to the Rambam's broader philosophy:

- The Rambam teaches that the purpose of mitzvot is **personal development** — character (through mitzvot) and intellect (through Torah).
- If someone does "extra" spiritual practices but then violates basics, it reveals they **were never truly at that level**. They hadn't actually developed; they just experienced a temporary high.

- It's like a drug-induced high — you feel elevated, but it's not who you actually are. Real growth is internal and permanent.
- **This is why Rabbi Avraham says "yitkapchu lecha" (it will be lost):** It's not that mitzvot cancel out — it's that you were never really there. The fast wasn't real growth if the basics aren't in place.

Chapter 1 Conclusion

Rabbi Avraham's closing statement:

"If you aspire to the level of the select few, to walk the intimate path with Hashem — the ways of the Chassidim, the ways of the prophets — you must first begin on the basic revealed path and fulfill it sincerely and completely. Do not neglect anything you are obligated in. Only then may you begin the unique path."

Summary of Chapter 1:

- **Two paths:** Basic (Tzadik) and Intimate (Chasid).
- The Chasid path has many nuances and levels.
- **Do not attempt to be a Chasid before being a Tzadik.**
- At minimum, we can aspire — aiming high brings us higher than aiming low.
- Go slowly up the ramp. No shortcuts.

Chapter 2 (Perek Bet) — Interconnection of Middot

This is a very short, introductory chapter.

Core Teaching: Good Middot Are Interconnected

"Da ki hamidot hatromiyot keruchot zo b'zo" — All good character traits are **interrelated, interconnected, and spring from one another**.

Training in one midah serves as **preparation and strengthening** for another.

Examples of Interconnected Traits

Trait A	Trait B	Connection
Compassion (*Rachmanut*)	Generosity (*Nedivut*)	The more generous you are, the easier it is to be merciful — and vice versa. A stingy person struggles with mercy.
Compassion (*Rachmanut*)	Patience / Slow to Anger (*Orech Apayim*)	A calm person can be merciful; a merciful person is generally slow to anger. A cruel person gets angry quickly.
Patience (*Orech Apayim*)	Humility (*Anavah*)	The more humble, the calmer; the calmer, the more humble.
Abstinence (*Prishut*)	Contentment with Little (*Histapkut B'mu'at*)	These naturally go together.
Fighting the Yetzer Hara	Trust in Hashem (*Bitachon*)	Interrelated — trust strengthens one's ability to resist temptation.

Practical observation: You find generous people are merciful, calm people are humble, those content with little can abstain from excess — all consistently.

The Reason: A Unified Purpose

"Sibat hadavar hi ki kol derachim halalu tachilitam achat" — The reason all middot are connected is that they all serve **one ultimate purpose**: becoming the best version of oneself in order to have a relationship with Hakadosh Baruch Hu.

The Mishnah: Lev Tov (A Good Heart)

Rabbi Avraham cites the famous Mishnah in Avot:

- Rabbi Yochanan ben Zakkai asked his five students: What is the best character trait?
- Various answers were given (a good eye, etc.)
- **Rabbi Elazar ben Arach said: Lev Tov — a good heart.**
- Rabbi Yochanan ben Zakkai agreed: "I prefer his words, for included in his words are all of yours."

A "good heart" is the **umbrella trait** — it encompasses everything. All middot development ultimately aims at making you a genuinely good person.

Connection to the Omer

- **Lev (לב) = 32, Tov (טוב) = 17 → Total = 49** — the gematria matches the 49 days of the Omer.
- The purpose of the Omer period is to work on middot, one each day — character development through Pirkei Avot and focused self-improvement.
- Purim is a week away; Pesach five weeks after that; the Omer begins in five weeks.

Practical Takeaway

The teacher urged: don't save middot-work for Elul alone. Think about it weekly, even daily:

- What am I doing this week to develop **patience**?
- What am I doing to develop **compassion** or **generosity**?
- What one thing can I do this week to develop **humility**?

Just being conscious of these things makes a difference.

Derech vs. Pegiyah (Path vs. Encounter)

Rabbi Avraham distinguishes between two stages:

- **Derech (Path):** The training phase — working on middot during our entire lives. This is where we are.
- **Pegiyah (Encounter):** The ultimate goal — devekut (cleaving) to Hashem. The moment of true spiritual communion.

Some middot relate directly to God's attributes (compassion, generosity, patience — we can speak of God as merciful, generous, slow to anger). Working on these is both *derech* (path) and approaching *pegiyah* (encounter), because we are emulating God's ways.

Other middot (e.g., abstinence, asceticism) don't relate to God's attributes — they are only *derech*, tools on the path.

The mitzvah of Devekut: *"U'vo tidbak"* — Cleave to God (Devarim 10:20). The Chachamim ask: how can the physical cleave to the spiritual? Answer: by **emulating His ways** (*Imitatio Dei*). The more similar we become to God in character, the closer the relationship — just as in human life, we bond with those similar to us.

Chapter 2 Conclusion

"V'atah korei, achar she'heivanta v'hiskalta... shit libcha v'da'atcha v'shkod al haperakim haba'im" — Now that you understand these first two chapters, pay close attention to the chapters ahead, about each of the elevated middot, which is the **purpose of the entire Torah** (as the Rambam says: the purpose of Torah is character improvement).

Summary of Chapter 2: Good middot are interconnected because they all serve a single purpose — drawing close to Hashem. Working on one strengthens others. The ultimate aim is devekut. The entire Torah's purpose is character development.

Chapter 3 (Perek Gimel) — Taharat HaMa'asim (Purity of Actions)

Translation & Meaning

- Literal: "Purity of Actions"
- Better translation: **Sincerity and precision in one's motives**
- Core idea (rooted in the Rambam): Serving Hashem **for the sake of serving Hashem** — without ulterior motive.

The Framework: Categories of Observant Jews

"Da ki shomrei haTorah nechlakkim b'yachas ma'aseihem b'kiyum hamitzvot l'kamah kitot" — Torah-observant people can be divided into groups based on **their motives** for keeping mitzvot.

There are **two extremes** and a **middle**. (Five levels total emerge.)

Level 1 (Lowest): Chanufah — Insincerity / Hypocrisy

Definition of Chanufah:

- Rashi: Acting wickedly.
- Ibn Ezra: Doing bad secretly (*asot ra b'seter*).
- Ramban: Doing the opposite of what appears to the eye (*asot hefech hanireh la'einayim*).
- In the Gemara generally: **Insincerity, hypocrisy** — acting one way while internally being another.
- Rabbi Avraham's usage here: Doing mitzvot **solely for the sake of other people's perception**.

Examples given:

1. **Keeps Shabbat and avoids chametz on Pesach** — but only because he fears being caught and punished. *If he could be sure no one would see, he wouldn't keep Shabbat.*
2. **Studies Torah** — only so people honor him and consider him knowledgeable, or for financial benefit.
3. **Prays extensively and prostrates** — so people think he's pious.
4. **Wears tzitzit constantly and puts on tefillin** — so people consider him a Chasid.

All of these: the person's motivation is entirely about other humans, not about Hashem.

Historical Note: Tzitzit Wearing Through the Ages

An interesting observation emerges from comparing sources across 300 years:

Rambam (c. 1200): *"Even though a person is not obligated to buy a four-cornered garment and wear tzitzit, it is not fitting for a Chasid to exempt himself from this mitzvah."* In the Rambam's time, regular Jews did **not** routinely wear tzitzit. Only the pious (*chasidim*) did.

Shulchan Aruch (c. 1500s): *"It is correct for every person to be careful to wear a tallit katan all day."* No longer just for *chasidim* — it had become the standard for **all** observant Jews.

This shows how the custom **evolved** from an act of piety to a baseline expectation.

On Tefillin: "Wears tefillin a lot" likely refers to wearing tefillin **all day** (not just during prayer), which was the practice of the especially pious.

Chazal's Terminology: Yuhara (Pretentiousness)

The Chachamim called this behavior **yuhara** — arrogance and pretentiousness in mitzvah observance.

- It appears in the *Al Cheit* on Yom Kippur: *"Al cheit shechatanu lefanecha b'yuhara."*
- The Chachamim were so concerned about yuhara that they **restricted certain optional practices** to prevent it.

Example 1 — The Chatan and Shema:

- Halacha: A groom is exempt from Shema on his wedding night.
- One opinion: Even if he *wants* to say Shema, he shouldn't — *chashinan l'yuhara* — we worry he'll develop pretentious thoughts ("Look how pious I am, even on my wedding night!").

Example 2 — Working on Tisha B'Av:

- In places where the custom is to work on Tisha B'Av, choosing not to work is considered yuhara.

Lishma vs. Shelo Lishma

Rabbi Avraham classifies this behavior as **"oseh Torato shelo lishma"** — doing Torah for the wrong motives.

The Midrash on Tehillim 111:10: *"Sechel tov l'chol oseihem"* — "Good understanding for all who do them" — interpreted as: for those who do them **lishma** (for their own sake). Those who do them shelo lishma: *"It would have been better had they not been created."*

The Apparent Contradiction in the Gemara:

- One statement: "Always learn Torah, even shelo lishma."
- Another statement: "One who learns shelo lishma — better he wasn't created."

Resolution (some Rishonim): There's a spectrum within shelo lishma:

- Learning for personal motives (honor, money) — not ideal, but still learn.
- Learning in order to **argue against and undermine others** (*l'kanter*) — this is truly destructive.

Rabbi Avraham's stricter position: Even basic shelo lishma (for personal honor/gain) yields no spiritual benefit from the mitzvah.

Still, Better Than Nothing

"U'v'chol zot, he'edif ha'oseh mitzvot b'ofen zeh al she'eino oseh klum" — Despite everything, doing mitzvot shelo lishma is **still better than doing nothing at all**, in the hope that one will eventually progress to a higher level.

The Harsh Truth

As long as people in this category do mitzvot only *l'mar'it ayin* (for appearance), they are like "empty people" (*anashim reikim*) before Hashem — because God judges the heart, not the external appearance.

"Ki ha'adam yir'eh la'einayim, v'Hashem yir'eh la'leivav" (Shmuel I 16:7) — Humans see the exterior; Hashem sees the heart.

Classification

This group is called by Chazal the **"Kat Chanefim"** (the sect of hypocrites) — one of the **four groups that do not receive the Divine Presence** (Sanhedrin 103a).

As it says: *"Ki lo lefanav chanef yavo"* (Iyov 13:16) — a hypocrite cannot come before God.

Where This Fits

This is **Level 1 of 5** — the lowest extreme. Next time: the opposite extreme (completely altruistic, pure lishma) and the levels in between.

Discussion Points from the Shiur

On Picking and Choosing (Will's Comment)

People often say "I'm spiritual but not religious" and take bits from various systems. This is essentially choosing the easy, feel-good parts while avoiding the hard foundational work of any single system. True spiritual development requires discipline and training, not just pleasant feelings.

Rabbi Yisrael Salanter's Teachings

1. **It is harder to correct one character trait** than to learn the entire Talmud.
2. **The Shochet's Story:** A shochet wanted to quit because he feared he may have fed people non-kosher food. He planned to go into business instead. Rabbi Salanter responded: "And you're not scared of sinning in business dealings with other people?" The lesson: we tend to be vigilant about dramatic religious concerns while neglecting the everyday ethical basics — exactly what Rabbi Avraham warns against.

Key Terms

Hebrew	Translation	Context
Derech Ha'Am HaGluyah	The Revealed Path	Basic mitzvah observance
Derech HaSegula / HaYachid	The Intimate/Unique Path	Going beyond the law; subject of this book
Tzadik	Righteous person	One who keeps mitzvot properly
Chasid	Pious person	One who goes beyond the mitzvot
Am Ha'aretz	Ignorant person	Cannot be a Chasid
Yuhara	Pretentiousness / Arrogance	Doing mitzvot to appear pious
Chanufah	Insincerity / Hypocrisy	Keeping mitzvot only for social reasons
Lishma	For its own sake	Proper motivation for mitzvot
Shelo Lishma	Not for its own sake	Improper motivation
Pegiyah	Encounter	The ultimate spiritual communion with Hashem
Devekut	Cleaving/Clinging	Attaching oneself to God through emulating His ways
Lev Tov	Good Heart	The all-encompassing character trait (gematria = 49)
Derech	Path	The journey/training phase of spiritual development

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Looking Ahead

- **No shiur next week** (Purim).
- Next session will continue Chapter 3: the remaining four levels of motivation in mitzvah observance, from the worst (chanufah, covered today) to the best (completely lishma / altruistic).

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